

WHS Guidelines – Rath Yatra



Introduction

Agenda:

- This session is to discuss a few key WHS areas of risk relevant to Rath Yatra, but also for ongoing mandir activities.
- Each centre would be having is own existing systems, so this serves as a guide to align on baseline practices and is designed to be adaptable for each centre’s use cases.
- Our objective is to ensure that WHS compliance is maintained at all times so that BAPS can host events that are as safe but enjoyable as possible.



Planning and Co-ordination

- WHS plans should be finalised at least 2 months before the event, or at the earliest possible time.
- Event location and key details must be confirmed early (ideally 2 months before) for planning and co-ordination purposes. This is of key importance, particularly when engaging with external parties and endorsing our insurance policies.
- All WHS-related decisions must be communicated to the designated leads and volunteers should not make hasty decisions independently without consulting them first.
- Establish clear roles and responsibilities for all safety personnel before any event.
- For Rath Yatra conducted on a public road, coordinate with local authorities well in advance to obtain necessary permits and approvals.
- Each section of the procession, should have designated leads responsible for safety within their group, ideally wearing vests.



External Co-ordination & Permits

- If the event is being held outside of mandir premises, in a public location such as roads or large parks, please ensure the following:
  - Engage with local council and police early in the planning process for public road processions.
  - Obtain all necessary permits, road closure approvals and traffic management plans.
  - Provide authorities with detailed event plans including route, timing, expected attendance and safety measures/processes.
  - Maintain clear communication channels with authorities on the day of the event.
  - Ensure compliance with all conditions specified in permits and approvals.
  - Have designated liaison personnel to coordinate with external authorities during the event.
  - All of the above information is required for endorsing public liability insurance.



Equipment Setup & Safety

- Ensure volunteers in Rath Yatra setup/wind-up are wearing appropriate PPE.
- Ensure appropriate safety measures are followed when using ladders and any tools/equipments.
- All electrical equipment, cables, plugs, etc. must meet appropriate safety standards. Proper cable management should be conducted to prevent tripping hazards.
- Use proper outdoor-rated equipment for external events (weatherproof where necessary).
- If there is any specialised equipment that is used, it should **only** be operated by qualified volunteers.
- Chariots should undergo thorough structural integrity checks before the event.
- Ensure all equipment related to chariot movement (ropes, wheels, braking mechanisms, etc.) are in good working condition.
- Cultural performers using equipment (such as musical instruments and flags) should keep a safe distance from each other.



Emergency Plan (incl. Vehicles)

- Emergencies can occur anytime, anywhere and require immediate attention and preparation.
- There should be at least 4 full-time First-Aid Officers rostered and present (with a Green First Aid Vest) at any given time to tend to such emergencies (2 male and 2 female, ideally). These volunteers **should not** be involved in other seva departments. A dedicated First-Aid marquee/area should be clearly marked on event maps/signage.
- If an issue has been identified by a First-Aid Officer, they should call and inform:
  - 000,
  - any medical professionals on-site (if required),
  - the Mandir Co-Ordinator
  - and the front security with the location details of the emergency. Security can also assist with crowd control.
- An emergency can also be identified by a bystander, who can call 000, hence, all specified people above should be prepared in case emergency vehicles do arrive unexpectedly.
- Upon arrival of the emergency vehicles, front security should direct them through the mandir premises to the location of the emergency. For the Rath Yatra, ensure that emergency vehicle access is maintained at all times along the route.
- An empty room on mandir premises should be available to treat the patient in private. For outdoor events, ideally a marquee setup with essential requirements.
- Access to wheelchairs should also be available.





Emergency Evacuation Plan

- All mandirs should have an emergency assembly point which all WHS leads & volunteers should be aware of.
- For larger events, respective departmental leads should also be made aware of the assembly point and emergency evacuation plan.
- If the emergency evacuation point is where we are conducting the activities, then we need to come up with an alternate emergency assembly point.
- Please ensure that emergency evacuation doors, corridors (including fire-exits) are unlocked and clear of any obstacles. The plans should also be printed and shown around the mandir premises.
- In the event of an emergency, all designated leads and volunteers, especially sabha vyavastha and security volunteers should guide people to the emergency assembly point.
- Please work with your local WHS leads & volunteers to ensure this plan is thoroughly discussed and if possible rehearsed. This discussion can also be added to regular admin/coordinator meetings to onboard new volunteers if necessary and keep this topic in the forefront.
- When hosting events in external indoor venues, such as community halls, we should learn the specific emergency evacuation plans for that location.
- When using public roads, coordinate emergency procedures with local authorities.





Weather Contingency

- Back-up plans must be prepared for adverse weather conditions.
- Consider postponement protocols if weather conditions pose safety risks.
- Ensure emergency corridors and doors remain accessible regardless of weather plans.



Procession & Chariot Safety

- Establish safe loading and unloading procedures for deities and any decorative elements. Only designated volunteers should be involved in chariot movement and control who should be wearing PPE.
- Ensure chariots are structurally sound and have functioning braking/stopping mechanisms.
- Children must be supervised and kept at safe distances from moving chariots.
- Have clear communication between the event leads, mandir coordinators and section leads.
- Ensure the route is clear of obstacles/hazards before commencing.



Road Safety & Traffic Management

- If the event is being held outside of mandir premises, in a public location such as roads or large parks, please ensure the following:
  - Implement comprehensive traffic management plans approved by local authorities.
  - Use appropriate signage, barriers and road closure equipment as required.
  - Maintain clear separation between procession participants, spectators and vehicle traffic.
  - Coordinate with police/traffic authorities for required support and make sure to adhere to all laws and regulations.



Food Stalls

- We should consider allergen requirements of the attendees. Volunteers at these stalls should ask for consent beforehand.
- Menus/signs for Shayona food stalls should contain basic allergen alerts, such as presence of nuts/gluten, etc. and include a clause to encourage attendees to inform volunteers of specific allergies.
- Volunteers in the kitchen/Shayona food stalls should be wearing gloves, hairnets, and other such hygiene equipment. Food that is leftover at the end should also be disposed and **not** carried over to the next day.



Crowd Management

- Plan appropriate crowd flow for the venue size and expected attendance.
- Ensure adequate space for movement, especially in high-traffic areas, such as around chariots and along the procession route.
- Consider entry/exit points and their capacity.
- Section leads should be positioned to guide and manage their groups throughout the procession.
- Identify potential bottleneck areas along the route and plan accordingly.
- Have protocols in place for managing unexpected crowd surges or congestion.